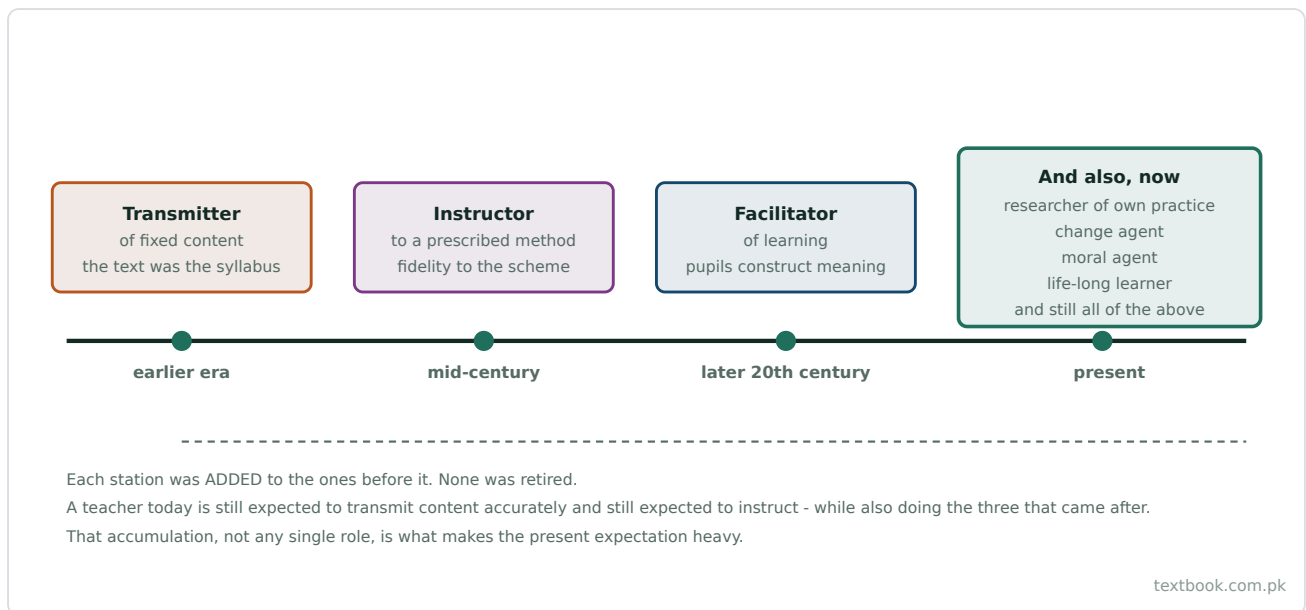


Topic 3.5 - The roles a teacher now has to play

A real classroom situation



Mr Imran has taught Class 8 general science for eleven years. He is good at it in the way Topic 3.1 would recognise: his explanations are clear, his room is orderly, his results are steady.

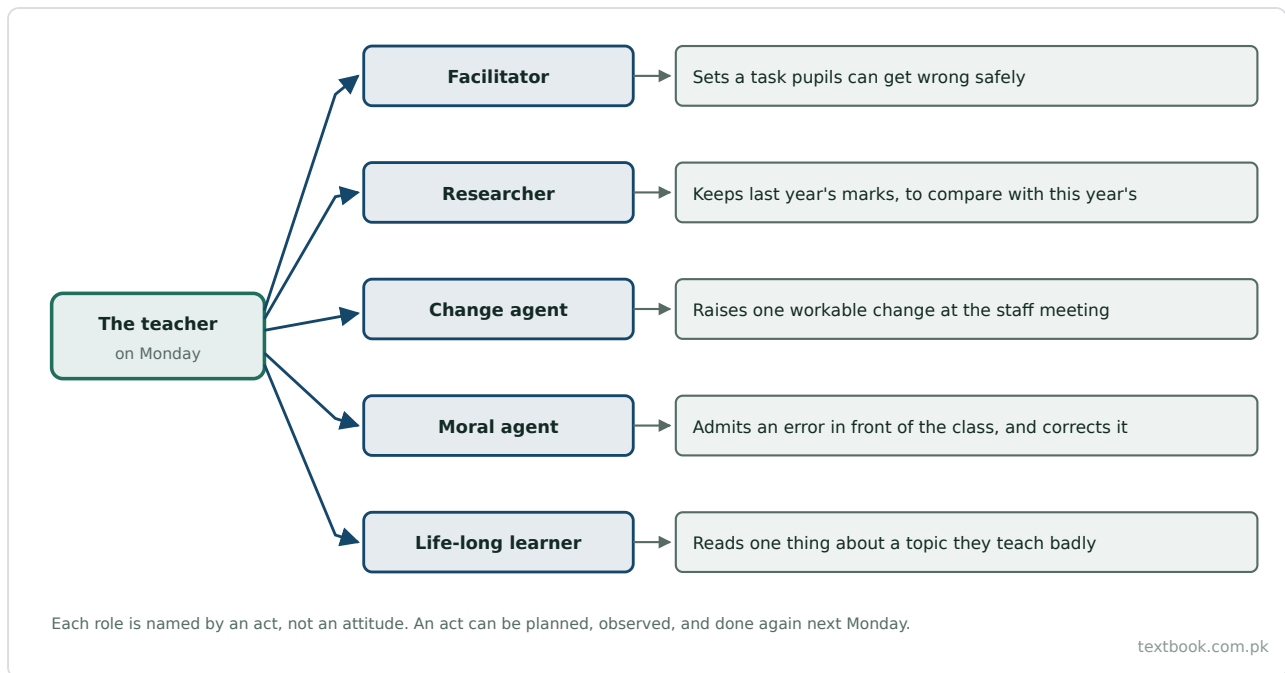
This year he tried something. He had noticed that pupils could state Newton's third law and could not use it, so he replaced two lessons of explanation with a sequence where pairs had to predict what would happen in four situations and then test them. He kept the marks from last year's class on the same topic, and compared.

The results were slightly worse. He kept the approach anyway, but changed how the pairs report back, because what the comparison actually showed him was that the pupils who struggled were the ones who had never been asked to commit to a prediction in front of a partner.

Everything in this topic is visible in that paragraph.

Explanation

The teacher as facilitator and as researcher



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Facilitator. The facilitator arranges the conditions under which pupils do the intellectual work, rather than doing it in front of them. The distinction is not about talking less. A facilitator may talk a great deal; what changes is who is doing the thinking at the moment that matters.

This is the role most often misunderstood in training. It does not mean withdrawing, and it does not mean that explanation is obsolete. A class cannot discover a convention, and letting them try wastes their time. What a facilitator judges is which parts of a topic are worth the cost of being worked out and which should simply be told. Mr Imran's two lessons were facilitation; his explanations of the units of force were not, and should not have been.

Researcher. The researcher treats their own classroom as a source of evidence about their own practice. Not published research: the ordinary, small version. Notice something, form a question, change one thing, collect something that would show whether it worked, and be willing to find out that it did not.

Mr Imran kept last year's marks. That single act is what separates a teacher who tries things from a teacher who learns from trying things. Most changes in teaching are adopted or abandoned on the basis of how the lesson felt, and how a lesson felt is a poor guide, because a lesson that feels smooth is often one in which nobody was made to struggle.

This role is the load-bearing one, and it is why it is paired with facilitator here. Facilitation introduces uncertainty into a lesson; the researcher role is what converts that uncertainty into information instead of anxiety.

The teacher as change agent and as moral agent

Change agent. The change agent improves something beyond their own room: a colleague's practice, a departmental habit, a school routine that is quietly failing pupils.

Trainees tend to hear this as a call for grand initiatives, and then, reasonably, conclude it does not apply to someone in their first year with no authority. The realistic version is smaller and available immediately: sharing a method that worked, raising a pattern you have noticed in a department meeting, declining to participate in a practice you judge harmful. Unit 2's account of obligations toward colleagues is this role seen from the ethical side.

The change agent role also has a failure mode worth naming: the new teacher who arrives convinced everything is wrong and says so. That is not change agency, it is a way of ensuring nobody listens to you for two years. Change requires standing, and standing is earned by being visibly good at the ordinary work first.

Moral agent. The moral agent recognises that teaching forms people, and that this happens whether or not it is intended. Unit 2 established the ground: a teacher is an ethical model because pupils learn conduct by watching an adult with authority.

What this role adds is deliberateness. A moral agent notices that the way marks are returned, the way a struggling pupil is spoken to, and who gets the benefit of the doubt are all teaching something about fairness, and chooses what to teach rather than leaving it to habit.

The teacher as life-long learner

The life-long learner keeps developing after qualification, including in the years when nobody is requiring it.

The argument for it is not exhortation. The content changes, the pupils change, and a method that worked for one cohort in one school does not transfer unexamined. More pointedly, the alternative to continued learning is not stability; it is the slow drift of a practice built for conditions that no longer exist.

Brookfield (2017) supplies the discipline: development that consists of collecting courses is weaker than development that involves examining your own habitual practice against evidence, including evidence of how pupils actually experienced it. Suarez and McGrath (2022) add the identity dimension, that a teacher's sense of who they are professionally keeps developing and needs support during change rather than being fixed at qualification.

This topic is deliberately last in the unit, because it is what makes the other four survivable. A facilitator will run lessons that fail. A researcher will discover that a favourite method does not work. A change agent will be rebuffed. None of that is sustainable for a person who expects to have arrived.

Why these are additions, not replacements

One caution about the timeline at the top of this topic. It is easy to read a sequence of eras as a story in which each role supersedes the last, and to conclude that a modern teacher does not transmit content.

That reading is wrong and does real damage. Pupils still need to be told things by someone who knows them. What has changed is that transmitting content is no longer *sufficient*, and the four later roles are what has been added on top. A teacher who facilitates but cannot explain has not advanced past transmission; they have skipped it.

Activity: One act per role

Work in groups of five, one role each.

For your role, write one specific act a first-year teacher could perform next Monday that would express it. It must be something a person with no authority and no budget could actually do, and it must be observable: someone watching the classroom should be able to see that it happened.

Read the five aloud. Then, as a group, identify which two of the five acts would be hardest to sustain for a whole term, and say what would make them fail.

Allow 25 minutes.

Check your understanding

1. Name the five roles and give one concrete classroom act for each.
(Remember)
2. Explain the difference between a teacher who tries new things and a teacher in the researcher role. *(Understand)*
3. Why is facilitation not the same as talking less? Give an example of a topic that should simply be explained. *(Apply)*
4. Explain why a new teacher who criticises everything is not acting as a change agent, and what they would have to do first. *(Analyze)*
5. Explain why reading the timeline as a sequence of replacements is a mistake, and what damage that reading does. *(Analyze)*

Summary

Five roles have been added to the teacher's job beyond transmitting content. The facilitator arranges conditions so pupils do the thinking, judging which parts of a topic are worth working out and which should be told. The researcher treats their own classroom as evidence about their own practice, and is what converts a tried change into a learned one. The change agent improves something beyond their own room, which requires standing earned by ordinary competence first. The moral agent recognises that teaching forms people and chooses deliberately what its habits teach. The life-long learner keeps developing afterwards, which is what makes the other four survivable, because each of them guarantees some failure.

These roles are additions to transmission, not replacements for it. A teacher who facilitates but cannot explain has skipped a stage rather than advanced beyond it.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can name the five roles and give a concrete, observable act for each.
- ☐ I can explain what the researcher role adds to simply trying new things.
- ☐ I can judge which parts of a topic warrant facilitation and which warrant explanation.
- ☐ I can describe a realistic change-agent act for someone with no authority.
- ☐ I can explain why the roles are cumulative rather than sequential.

Try this at your practicum school

Do one small piece of classroom research. Pick one thing you have noticed about your class, change one thing about how you teach it, and decide **in advance** what you will collect that would show whether it worked.

The decision in advance is the whole exercise. A measure chosen afterwards will confirm whatever you hoped, and choosing it beforehand is what makes the result capable of surprising you.

Write half a page on what you found, including whether you were willing to conclude that it did not work.

Summative task

Write 450 to 500 words.

Take Mr Imran's case from the top of this topic. Identify every role he exercised, and evaluate his decision to keep an approach whose results were slightly worse.

Name each role with the specific evidence in the vignette, then argue whether keeping the approach was defensible. Your answer must engage with the obvious objection that results got worse and that a professional should follow the evidence.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Role identification (Apply)	Names each role with the exact evidence, rather than asserting the roles are present
Grasp of the researcher role	Recognises that the comparison, not the innovation, is what makes his practice researched
Evaluation of the decision (Evaluate)	Engages seriously with "the results got worse", distinguishes the measure from the learning, and reaches a defended verdict rather than praising him for trying
Use of evidence	Distinguishes what the vignette states from what is inferred

Further reading

- Brookfield, S. D. (2017). *Becoming a critically reflective teacher* (2nd ed.). Jossey-Bass.
- Suarez, V., & McGrath, J. (2022). *Teacher professional identity: How to develop and support it in times of change* (OECD Education Working Paper No. 267). OECD Publishing. <https://doi.org/10.1787/b19f5af7-en>

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